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Exploratory Study of Public Relations Roles in Zimbabwe

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ABSTRACT

This exploratory study examined the practice of public relations in Zimbabwe by surveying and understanding public relations roles typically practiced by Zimbabwean PR practitioners. Through the lens of systems theory, the research investigated whether the practiced public relations roles allow organizations to perform all three boundary spanning functions such as output, throughput, and input. The results confirmed prior theoretically and empirically derived typology of roles (technician, manager, strategist) from the African continent. However, the observed structures of public relations roles deviate from previous findings, indicating that Zimbabwean PR practitioners' professional roles may differ from those in neighboring countries.

1. Introduction

Amplified cultural, economic, and professional globalization has re-introduced the concept of public relations roles into the scholarly agenda, as research on international public relations roles becomes a necessary and crucial function in further understanding the practice of public relations in different countries (Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011). Increasingly, scholars have called for and offered more culturally diverse public relations research. Creedon and Al-Khaja (2019) highlighted the need "to move the discipline's scholarship from global isolation to cultural inclusivity" (p. 84) through broadening research outreach. This exploratory study looks at the practice of public relations in Zimbabwe, an understudied African country with an active public relations industry and a long history of the profession. Specifically, the current study contributes to the ongoing discussion about whether the structure and performance of public relations roles differ across national and cultural borders and how it defines the profession globally (Vercic, Grunig, & Grunig, 1996).

Previous research showed that Zimbabwe has had an active chapter of the International Public Relations Association (IPRA) and its own Institute of Public Relations since 1966 and has PR practitioners working in several sectors (Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018). Yet, its inclusion in public relations studies is lacking (Ngondo, 2019). In fact, of the 54 African countries, only a handful of nations have been studied in connection with public relations: Kenya (e.g., Kiambi & Nadler, 2012); South Africa (e.g., Holtzhausen, Petersen, & Tindall, 2003; Holtzhausen, 2005; Rensburg & Botha, 2014; Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011); Nigeria (e.g.,

Molleda & Alhassan, 2006; Ukonu, Anyadike, & Okoro, 2018); Ghana (e.g., Wu & Baah-Boakye, 2009, 2014); Uganda, Mauritius, Guinea, and Tanzania (Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005), and most recently Zimbabwe (Muchena, 2017, 2018; Ngondo, 2019; Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018, among others).

This study widens the research coverage of the African continent by surveying Zimbabwean PR practitioners to explore their professional roles and understanding of public relations. Further, this study contributes to the recognition of cultural diversity in the practice and theory of public relations, as urged by Dutta and Elers (2020). Similar to Azionya, Oksiutycz, and Benecke (2019), who asserted that their research offered a new way of representing marginalized voices in public relations education and industry, this current research follows suit. First, it extends and clarifies previous work on public relations roles in Africa by Steyn (1999), Tindall and Holtzhausen (2011), and Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005), whose research included participants from countries such as Uganda, Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa, Mauritius, Guinea, and Tanzania. In so doing, it confirms previous theoretically and empirically derived typology of roles, yet observes a variation in the structure of those roles in comparison to the earlier findings on the African continent. Second, the study offers a unique insight into the public relations activities and the composition of the public relations labor force in Zimbabwe and adds to the kaleidoscope of understandings of global public relations with its specific focus on Zimbabwe.

In what follows, the manuscript briefly discusses public relations research conducted in Africa, provides background on the public relations practice and education, and gives an overview of public relations

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research in Zimbabwe. Then, we introduce a theoretical framework that informed this study and detail previous research on public relations roles around the globe, followed by an explanation of the methodology, reporting of results, and discussion of the findings.

1.1. Public Relations Research in Africa

The public relations profession and related phenomena have been studied in several African countries. As part of an emerging agenda, most research on public relations in Africa seeks to understand the profession in general, models of practice, professional public relations roles, as well as examine various cases of strategic communication campaigns. Previously, researchers examined public relations education in an emerging democracy such as Ghana, aiming to understand how future PR practitioners are shaped in different socio-political contexts (Thompson, 2018). Wu and Baah-Boakye (2014) also studied professionalization of public relations in Ghana and concluded that the field is moving toward professionalism as practitioners become involved in conducting more summative and formative research for their organizations and clients. Similarly, in Ghana and Kenya, Kiambi and Nadler (2012) examined Grunig and Hunt's (1984) four Western-centric public relations models (press agency, public information, two-way asymmetrical, and two-way symmetrical), and two international models - the personal influence model and the cultural interpreter model (Grunig, Grunig, Sriramesh, Huang, & Lyra, 1995). Among the six public relations models, the cultural interpreter model and the personal influence model emerged as the most frequently used in Ghana and Kenya (Kiambi & Nadler, 2012; Wu & Baah-Boakye, 2009).

In Nigeria, Ukonu et al. (2018) found that the public relations practice follows what they called a British paternalistic model, or government influence model, tied to the history of the British colonial rule. Ukonu et al. (2018) concluded that the profession was undergoing an identity crisis, in which different industries were using the classic four public relations models differently. Yet, Nigerian public relations was linked more to the British style (government influence) but informed by American pedagogical practices. According to Ukonu et al. (2018), this dichotomy has made it difficult for Nigerian practitioners to evolve and construct their own public relations identity.

South Africa has been the site of most research on public relations conducted on the continent. For example, Holtzhausen et al. (2003) studied the application of symmetric principles among South African PR practitioners and found that they developed their models of public relations practice based on the socio-political and cultural environments. Scholars examined South African public relations through the lens of communication management (Rensburg, 2014), strategic communication (Steyn, 2009), financial communication (Rensburg & Botha, 2014), cultural intermediaries (Benecke et al., 2017), and public relations education (Azionya et al., 2019). Scholars also explored public relations as activism contributing to social dialogue and social change (Benecke & Oksitycz, 2015), and studied public relations roles predominantly occupied and practiced by South African practitioners (Steyn, 1999; Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011; Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005). Additionally, South Africa was included in the Global Capability Framework study (Gregory & Fawkes, 2019), which aimed to describe the scope and the roles of the profession on an international level to provide practitioners a standardized understanding of public relations competencies and best practices.

These disparate findings from the African continent accentuate the need to understand public relations' practice diversity, especially from the understudied countries such as Zimbabwe. The nations on the African continent vary significantly, and it is important to consider how public relations practices and uses may differ based on a country or a sub-region to help build a scholarly agenda for future inquiries.

1.2. Background on Zimbabwe Public Relations

Zimbabwe is a landlocked country in Southern Africa and is bordered by such nations as Botswana, Zambia, Mozambique, and South Africa. It has a population of a little over 14 million people, 16 official languages, including English, with Harare as the capital city (Central Intelligence Agency, CIA, n.d.). A former British colony, Zimbabwe gained its independence in 1980. Zimbabwe's economy heavily relies on mining and agriculture. Like the United States, Zimbabwe is a member of several international organizations such as the United Nations, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank, and the World Trade Organization (US Department of State, n.d.). Zimbabwe is a host to such global companies as Coca-Cola, Nestle, Chevron, Price Waterhouse, British Petroleum, Barclays Bank, and British American Tobacco, among others, presenting a fertile market for the public relations industry.

According to Mawarera (2014), Zimbabwe's public relations practice can be traced back to the mid-1950s. By the mid-1960s, the industry had been actively developing with the founding of the Rhodesia Public Relations Institute in 1966, renamed to Zimbabwe Institute of Public Relations (ZIPR) after Zimbabwe's independence from Great Britain (Oksitycz & Nhedzi, 2018).

1.2.1. Public Relations Education in Zimbabwe

Although professional organizations such as IPRA and ZIPR have existed since the late 1960s, formal public relations education and training is still in its infancy in Zimbabwe. To date, no Zimbabwean university offers public relations as a full qualification. In contrast, all three public universities in Zimbabwe offer accredited undergraduate or postgraduate degrees in marketing (Oksitycz & Nhedzi, 2018), where PR practitioners often receive their education.

Most PR practitioners in Zimbabwe receive education via on-the-job training, postgraduate diplomas offered by ZIPR (Muchena, 2017), or certificates offered by South African companies such as Oracle Seven Investments, who solicit Zimbabwean PR professionals to undergo 10-day training programs that cover topics such as media relations, speech writing, social media management, and public relations management (B. Tonhodzayi, Group PR and Corporate Affairs Manager at Zimpapers, personal communication, November 27, 2019).

Similar to other countries' experiences, PR practitioners in Zimbabwe are often transplants to public relations from different disciplines, predominantly journalism and media studies (Muchena, 2017). In Zimbabwe, ZIPR is among the few organizations offering specialized courses in public relations, consistently expressing concern regarding limited opportunities for formal training. ZIPR offers its diploma program in-person or online, which is taught by practitioners. The diploma covers public relations theory and practice, media relations, public speaking, speech writing, information technology in public relations, grooming, and personal branding, etc. (ZIPR LinkedIn, 2019). However, this program is not accredited by the Zimbabwe Council for Higher Education (ZIMCHE) and, therefore, cannot qualify as formal education, and its courses are heavily rooted in media studies (Muchena, 2017).

Muchena (2018) noted how public relations education is often included as a module in marketing, English, communication, media studies, or human resources and customer care, but not as a standalone degree. This trend is reflected in how the public relations industry and its labor force are constructed. Zimbabwean PR practitioners have varied educational backgrounds and operate either as independent departments or attached to other branches within the company with combined functions in marketing and sales (Muchena, 2017, 2018).

In recent years, the Zimbabwean government charged higher education to reflect industry trends (Matambo, 2018). In 2018, the Marketers Association of Zimbabwe (MAZ), in partnership with Bindura University of Science Education, started offering a two-year professional diploma called Public Relations and Corporate Reputation Management. The diploma-granting program, developed with local and international industry experts in marketing and public relations, aimed to address the

problem of formal training and bridge the gap between education and practice (Matambo, 2018), further highlighting the intertwining of public relations and marketing in Zimbabwe. Given the limited educational opportunities for PR professionals in Zimbabwe, defining public relations roles and untangling public relations interpretations based on different professional and educational backgrounds becomes critical in furthering our knowledge of public relations in different countries, like Zimbabwe.

1.3. Public Relations Research in Zimbabwe

Despite its public relations' history, Zimbabwe is a relative newcomer to the public relations scholarly agenda. The available research on Zimbabwe public relations addresses such issues as corporate social responsibility (CSR), social media use, and public relations' strategic management function. Masuku and Moyo (2013) investigated CSR in Zimbabwe as an "invention of PR" (p. 113). The authors interviewed PR professionals and found that "the management function of PR can play a positive role in society, while CSR demands to reduce the self-interest of organisations in their preferences and actions within" (p. 121). Further, the Zimbabwean practitioners believed that CSR could augment corporate identity and bolster corporate citizenship as an invention of public relations. Interestingly, Kakava, Mbizi, and Manyeruke (2013) found that over half of Zimbabwean companies prefer to engage in philanthropic CSR with short-lived benefits to the community rather than contributing toward long-term sustainable development. Masuku and Shava (2014), however, showed how the public relations department at Nestle Zimbabwe used CSR to enhance its reputation via activities such as sponsoring music festivals, sports events, and initiating health and education programs.

Ngondo (2019) investigated the use of social media and other digital technologies among Zimbabwean PR practitioners and found that the emergence of new media changed the way Zimbabwean communication professionals communicate and handle external and internal communication. Blogging and social media became the routine responsibilities of Zimbabwean PR practitioners. The practitioners also aspired to become primarily responsible for monitoring and managing all aspects of the organization's digital communication (Ngondo, 2019). As argued by Ngondo (2019), these findings stress the importance for public relations to continue to set itself apart, specifically from marketing, in the African region.

Muchena (2017, 2018) investigated the role public relations played in private and public organizations in Zimbabwe and observed that the practice's perception differs from the actual practice, a gap particularly pronounced in public institutions. Muchena (2017) interviewed practitioners to examine whether they perceive public relations as a strategic management function. In parallel with the understanding of the technician-manager role dichotomy, Muchena (2017) examined the technical and strategic communicative functions of public relations and concluded that Zimbabwean practitioners generally understand public relations as a strategic management function in line with the Western definitions of public relations. However, in his later study, Muchena (2018) found that public relations is practiced as a technical function dominated by such activities as news release writing and event planning. To address this gap, Muchena (2018) called for more studies on Zimbabwean public relations practice to develop its own body of literature that "advances local theory and practice relevant to the Zimbabwean situation" (p. 59). This study of public relations roles in Zimbabwe responds to the call for more diversified research from the African continent and Zimbabwe. It is the first attempt to understand public relations roles in this nation.

2. Literature Review

The objective of this study is to explore the existing public relations roles typically practiced by Zimbabwean professionals. Described as

patterns of behavior that determine everyday professional activities and functions of PR practitioners, public relations roles reflect different positions and ranks PR practitioners occupy in organizations (Grunig & Hunt, 1984). For this reason, this research investigated whether a public relations function in organizations is performed at all three levels: the organizational or macro level, functional or meso level, and implementational or micro level (Steyn, 1999), and whether it is reflected in how public relations roles manifest themselves in Zimbabwe.

2.1. Boundary Spanning and Public Relations Roles

The systems theory perspectives on public relations argue that an organization is a system separated from its external environment by a boundary through which information flows (Dozier & Broom, 2006). One of the key PR professionals' tasks is to span this boundary with "one foot in the organization and one foot outside" (Grunig & Hunt, 1984, p. 9) to allow the information to circulate from the organization to the environment and from the environment to the organization to ensure informed decision making. PR practitioners also span the boundaries to reach different publics inside and outside of the organization.

Organizations as systems can be closed and open, as well as something in between. Closed systems organizations are isolated, and their boundaries are considered impenetrable, discouraging information exchange. For this reason, organizations that operate as closed systems are not as quick and flexible to address emerging issues and are usually reactionary to crises (Cutlip, Center, & Broom, 2006). Public relations function in closed systems is confined to one-way communication. Organizations as open systems regard the environment as essential for their survival and continuous success. These organizations facilitate information exchange through the boundary spanning function afforded by public relations. The role of public relations in open systems is focused on two-way communication and relationship building (Cutlip et al., 2006; Grunig, Grunig, & Dozier, 2002).

For an organization to survive and thrive in an environment, the information flow process needs to include such steps as input, output, and throughput (Cutlip et al., 2006; Grunig et al., 2002). The input happens in the form of research, environmental scanning, and messages to the organization. For example, PR professionals use formal and informal research to collect information about key publics and issues and deliver them back to the organization. In addition, understanding the attitudes and behaviors of key publics is essential to organizations as they plan their goals and strategies (Mehta & Xavier, 2009). This information input function corresponds to the strategist role (Steyn, 1999, 2009).

The process through which information from the environment is handled is known as throughput. During the throughput stage, the input data (information) is organized and managed, and possible solutions to issues are identified and formulated. This information throughput function corresponds to the manager role (Steyn, 1999, 2009). Importantly, via the throughput function, information output is prepared.

Finally, output describes the process through which information flows back from the organization into the environment in the form of organizational messages, including news releases, annual reports, social media posts, etc. This information output function corresponds to the technician role (Steyn, 1999, 2009). To evaluate the impact of outputs, organizations may seek feedback from the publics that is delivered to the organizations as input, creating a feedback loop essential for two-way communication. Therefore, this process is circular and characterizes an open system (Grunig & Hunt, 1984).

Based on the systems theory, public relations roles can be conceptualized along the lines of functions associated with activities necessary to carry out the process of information input, throughput, and output. Broom (1986) described the function of public relations as "gathering, assimilating, interpreting and disseminating intelligence about the environment" (p. 2), providing a meaningful link between the systems theory perspectives on public relations (Grunig et al., 2002) and the

public relations roles framework (Cutlip et al., 2006).

2.2. Public Relations Roles

The concept of 'roles' refers to PR practitioners' everyday activities and is key to understanding public relations. Public relations roles are the behavioral patterns of individuals in organizations practicing public relations. These roles set individuals apart and define expectations from the organizations' perspectives. Public relations roles were first introduced by Broom and Smith (1979) as four types: expert prescriber, communication facilitator, problem-solving process facilitator, and PR/communication technician. Dozier (1983) empirically tested these roles and observed a strong link among three out of four roles suggesting that expert prescriber, problem-solving process facilitator, and communication facilitator represent different functions and responsibilities of a PR practitioner at a manager level (see also Cutlip et al., 2006; Dozier & Broom, 1995), submitting that PR practitioners can be described as performing either a technician role or a manager role within the organization. Importantly, Dozier (1983) warned that the line between technicians and managers is a blurry one and that the terms do not describe completely separate categories, but rather *predominant* roles.

The research on public relations roles has been conducted in different parts of the world and different contexts, highlighting the public relations practice's multiformity. For example, Beurer-Züllig, Fieseler, and Meckel (2009) investigated the typologies of communicators in Europe, taking into consideration differences in cultural and national contexts. They identified five distinct types of European communication professionals: negotiators, brand officers, policy advisors, internal communicators, and press agents. The authors concluded that these five roles fall "in line with Dozier's and Broom's manager-technician dichotomy," with two out of five roles representing manager roles and three out of five are in essence technician-level roles (Beurer-Züllig et al., 2009, p. 159).

Arguing that social media is one of the essential duties that should be reflected in today's public relations roles, Neill and Lee (2016) studied and identified seven social media roles: social media technician, social listening and analytics, online media relations, policymaker, employee recruiter, internal social media manager, and policing. Although these roles emerged in the context of social media, "five of these new roles were correlated with the traditional public relations manager role, but only three of them (...) with the communication technician role" (p. 13).

Seeking to understand the public relations roles of South African practitioners, Steyn (1999, 2009) introduced the role of a strategist to the original binary conceptualization of the technician-manager roles. Specifically, Steyn (1999) argued that the three public relations roles of strategist, manager, and technician correspond to three functions of PR practitioner as a boundary spanner: input, throughput, and output. According to Steyn (1999), these roles and functions are performed at three levels: the organizational or macro level, functional or meso level, and implementational or micro level (Steyn, 1999). Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005) later, empirically, verified the existence of these public relations roles among practitioners in seven Southern and Eastern African countries. However, in their study, the role of technician and manager were combined as responsibilities between these two functions were indistinct. In contrast, the strategist's role emerged as a strong indicator of the growing importance of the input function in South Africa's public relations practice.

Similarly, Tindall and Holtzhausen (2011) examined the roles of strategic communication professionals in South Africa. Their research discovered four roles specific to South Africa: strategist, media specialist, liaison, and cultural interpreter. Interestingly, the strategist role emerged as the most unified, while the role of media specialist represented a blend between the roles of communication technician and media relations. Tindall and Holtzhausen's (2011) findings demonstrated that political and cultural environments shape public relations

roles' context and content. Their study also recommended a differentiated approach to accept the notion that roles are not mutually exclusive and can be performed cross-functionally.

Different taxonomies and typologies of public relations roles exist depending on the applied theoretical framework. However, many scholars find consistent support for Dozier's general binary conceptualization of public relations roles: manager and technician, or different combinations of the two. While presenting important cultural particularities in performing public relations roles in different countries and contexts, studies find that those unique and culture-specific roles fit under the umbrella of the manager and/or technician (Beurer-Züllig et al., 2009; Steyn, 2009). Since this study is informed by the systems theory perspective to investigate how the boundary spanning function of public relations in the organizations is performed at different levels (macro, meso, micro), we chose to focus on two traditional public relations roles of manager and technician (Dozier & Broom, 2006), and the role of strategist proposed by Steyn (1999).

2.2.1. Micro level: Public relations technician

The role of the public relations technician is performed at the micro or program/implementational level (Steyn, 1999). This role is associated with the output function of PR practitioners as boundary spanners (Steyn, 1999). As conceptualized by Dozier (1984) and Broom and Smith (1979), the communication technician is responsible for program implementation by preparing and disseminating public relations tactics, such as brochures, news releases, speeches, fact sheets, social media posts, photographs, etc. Mehta and Xavier (2009) argued that the notion that public relations technicians are still focused on production and dissemination endures in the digital age. Such continuance was exemplified by Neill and Lee (2016) when they identified three social media roles that focused on meso level activities such as social media technician, policymaker and policing.

2.2.2. Meso level: Public relations manager

The role of the public relations manager is performed at the meso or functional level. In this capacity, PR practitioners are responsible for developing communication policies and programs, managing information input, determining what and how it should be communicated to the publics, identifying, managing, and anticipating threats coming from the external and internal environments. In the age of social media, public relations managers are also held accountable for program outcomes, including social media campaigns. This role is associated with the throughput function of PR practitioners as boundary spanners when information is shared internally with the relevant decision-makers to help develop an overall corporate communication strategy (Dozier & Broom, 2006).

2.2.3. Macro level: Public relations strategist

The role of the public relations strategist is performed at the macro or organizational level. Steyn (1999) argued that public relations managers often act as strategists when dealing with the dominant coalition. Public relations strategists are involved in research, social listening, and decision-making at the macro level to understand the external and internal environments and determine the approach an organization takes toward communication with stakeholders. Steyn (1999; 2002) also argued that PR practitioners' role at the macro level also defines how public relations is practiced at the meso and micro levels and what public relations model is predominantly practiced. This role is associated with the input function of PR practitioners as boundary spanners - when PR professionals assume responsibility for developing an overall communication strategy for the organization based on information input coming in the form of research, media monitoring and environmental scanning, social listening, issue tracking. Public relations strategists use this input to identify strategic stakeholders, detect and anticipate changes in the environment, identify issues affecting the publics' attitudes and opinions toward the organization.

Research on public relations roles presents mixed results, indicating that, in different contexts, practitioners may predominantly perform technical functions while others predominantly enact manager or strategist roles (Steyn, 1999; Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011). In some instances, the lines between manager and technician roles are blurred, allowing for the emergence of new, blended roles (Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005). The limited research on Zimbabwe demonstrated that practitioners perceive their role as strategic management, yet they perform largely at the micro (output) level, associated with the technician role (2018, Muchena, 2017). To better understand the practice of public relations and the structure of public relations roles enacted by Zimbabwean professionals, we pose the following research questions:

RQ1: How do Zimbabwean PR practitioners define their public relations roles and activities? What are the distinct public relations roles enacted by Zimbabwean PR practitioners?

In what way do Zimbabwean PR practitioners perform the boundary spanning functions associated with these roles and activities?

RQ2: In what way do Zimbabwean PR practitioners understand public relations? What is the relationship between the way public relations is understood and the existing public relations roles?

3. Method

Consistent with prior research on public relations roles (Beurer-Züllig et al., 2009; Li, Cropp, Sims, & Jin, 2012; Neill & Lee, 2016; Steyn, 1999; Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005), the researchers administered previously developed and tested survey instrument (Steyn, 1999; Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005). Data for the study was collected online using Qualtrics, because online distribution provides access to a worldwide population, as well as to specialized and hidden populations, such as PR practitioners in Zimbabwe. It also provides convenience, an opportunity for immediate feedback, and tailored questions (Wimmer & Dominick, 2006).

3.1. Study Population and Sampling Procedure

Due to this study's exploratory nature and lack of formalized knowledge about the public relations industry in Zimbabwe, participants were recruited through a combination of purposive and snowball sampling methods, starting with professionals personally known to one of the researchers who is from Southern Africa. The study population included self-identified media, public relations, communication, and marketing professionals. Previous studies showed that various educational paths and experiences could lead to a career in public relations (Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018). In many countries with developing economies, PR practitioners may wear mismatched job titles while performing public relations duties (2018, Muchena, 2017). For this reason, before taking part in the survey, all participants had to answer a screener question asking, "In your current role, do you practice public relations (PR) or PR-related activities in Zimbabwe?" Those who answered "yes" moved forward with completing the questionnaire while those who answered "no" were thanked for their time, and the survey was terminated.

Low response rates, traditionally associated with international research (Kent, Taylor, & Turcilo, 2006), were neutralized by offering respondents a \$15 incentive to cover Internet and mobile data usage costs. Internet and/or mobile data access is available in most areas in Zimbabwe, so access was not a challenge. Upon completing the questionnaire, participants were redirected to a separate page to claim compensation to safeguard anonymity. In addition, the four-step distribution process was used, and invitation emails were sent to all potential participants once a week over four weeks. The follow-up correspondence was conducted per Dilman's (1978) recommendations, who argued that this method allows researchers to maximize the

response rate. The researchers received 347 total responses ($N = 347$), with 242 surveys usable for analysis. This number exceeded Van Heerden and Rensburg's (2005) response rate of 151 East African participants and Steyn's (1999) response rate of 103 South African participants.

3.2. Instrument

This study utilized a survey instrument previously developed by Steyn (1999) and re-designed by Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005) to capture the performed public relations roles: technician, manager, and strategist. The survey consisted of 36 multi-layered questions. The measurement instrument developed by Steyn (1999) was included fully as a reliable, previously tested tool. Specifically, the measurement for the construct of the technician role included six items ($\alpha = .885$), the construct of the manager role consisted of five items ($\alpha = .909$) and the construct of the strategist role had 10 items ($\alpha = .938$). All items were measured on a 5-point Likert scale from strongly disagree to strongly agree. For example, respondents had to indicate their level of agreement or disagreement with such statements as "A current activity of the PR department in our organization is to develop public relations strategy that supports corporate strategy." Statement responses were coded so that the higher value indicated the presence of the concept, meaning that a PR practitioner indeed engaged with the specified activity (see Table 1 for a complete list of items).

In addition, the survey asked questions about the participants' professional, educational, and socio-economic backgrounds. Specifically, the researchers sought out such information about the participants as gender, age, level of education and major, type of employer, industry, and working experience in public relations. To ensure that the instrument is appropriately localized and contextualized, the researchers consulted with three Zimbabwean PR practitioners to check terminology related to job titles, professional organizations, education levels, etc. The instrument was in English as it is one of the official languages spoken throughout Zimbabwe and used in education and business.

3.3. Data Analysis

To answer the first research question, principal component analysis (PCA) was performed on 21 survey items that represented various public relations activities associated with three types of public relations roles. PCA was used because it explores the overall variability of the data and helps generate a minimum number of components that account for the maximum number of variance in the data (Tabachnik & Fidell, 2007). To answer the second research question, composite variables of public relations roles (technician, manager, strategist) were created to run a correlation analysis and calculate the Pearson product-moment correlation coefficient. In addition, preliminary analyses were performed to ensure there was no violation of the assumptions of normality, linearity, and homoscedasticity. The results of the analyses are reported in the next section.

4. Results

4.1. Demographic Characteristics of the Sample

The sample under study consisted of individuals with diverse educational and professional backgrounds. The sample's composition was consistent with previous research suggesting that various educational paths and experiences can lead to a career in public relations (Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018). Over half of respondents (51.4%, $n = 125$) were female, 46.1% ($n = 112$) were male, while 2.5% ($n = 6$) preferred not to answer. The respondents' average age was 32, with the youngest respondent being 20 years old and the oldest being 60 years old. The majority of participants were black (97.1%, $n = 235$), five identified as mixed, and one person identified as white.

Table 1

Item analysis for constructs of technician role, manager role, strategist role.

	Current activity of the PR department in our organization is...	<i>n</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>a</i>
V2.1	To keep a media clipping service (clip articles that appeared in the media about the organization)	236	3.85	1.03	.885
V2.2	To organize special events (e.g., open houses/exhibitions/gala evenings)	230	4.11	.944	
V2.3	To produce audio-visual materials for presentations	227	4.08	.947	
V2.4	To write articles for the organization's publications	228	4.30	.925	
V2.5	To edit public relations materials (e.g., speeches/the annual report)	228	4.29	.859	
V2.6	To generate publicity (e.g., write media releases)	227	4.33	.893	.909
V3.1	To take responsibility for the success or the failure of public relations plans	238	4.09	.941	
V3.2	To develop public relations strategy that supports corporate strategy	229	4.33	.854	
V3.3	To manage the implementation of public relations plans	229	4.33	.943	
V3.4	To take responsibility for the success or the failure of the public relations strategy	230	4.21	.882	
V3.5	To monitor the performance of public relations practitioners/subdivisions	228	4.18	.911	.938
V4.1	To explain to top management the impact of their behavior (obtained through research) on key external publics	239	4.03	.982	
V4.2	To act as an 'early warning system' to top management before issues in society erupt into a crisis for our organization.	231	4.19	.942	
V4.3	To act as an advocate for key internal public by explaining their views to top management.	228	4.13	.937	
V4.4	To initiate dialogue with pressure groups in society that are limiting the organization's autonomy.	230	3.97	.953	
V4.5	To explain views/opinions that exist in society to top management.	231	4.17	.933	.938
V4.6	To bring to top management's attention any organizational behavior that erodes public trust.	229	4.22	.940	
V4.7	To bring to top management's attention societal expectations for socially responsible behavior.	230	4.10	.975	
V4.8	To explain to top management the impact of the organization's behavior on society.	231	4.23	.880	
V4.9	To express the company's stance on social responsibility to society in order to gain public trust.	230	4.26	.881	
V4.10	To act as an advocate for key external publics by explaining their views to top management	228	4.11	.951	

The respondents in the study varied in their educational background as well. About half of the respondents (49.5%, $n = 120$) had a bachelor's degree, 21.5% ($n = 52$) had a master's degree, 15.8% ($n = 38$) had some level of post-secondary education, 11.2% ($n = 27$) had some level of high school education, one person indicated no schooling completed, and two people reported having a Ph.D. The educational emphasis of those respondents who reported having a degree was in such disciplines as marketing (23%, $n = 54$), public relations (14%, $n = 33$), mass communication (13.6%, $n = 32$), business administration (11.1%, $n = 26$), journalism (9.4%, $n = 22$), and advertising (1.3%, $n = 3$). In addition, participants reported majoring in other fields, including human resources, international relations, information technology, and psychology.

Participants' professional experiences varied in terms of types of organizations respondents worked for, and types of positions held, with an average of six years of experience working in public relations. The largest group of respondents indicated that they were employed by a

private company or a corporation (28.6%, $n = 69$), 25.3% ($n = 61$) worked for a government ministry, 24.1% ($n = 58$) for a nonprofit, 4.1% ($n = 10$) for an agency, 3.3% ($n = 8$) were educators, and 11.6% ($n = 28$) reported to be self-employed or freelancers. Further, almost half of respondents (47.7%, $n = 115$) described their job level as mid-management level, 29.5% ($n = 71$) as entry-level, and 21.6% ($n = 52$) as senior management level.

4.2. Descriptive Analysis of the Data

Before performing factor analysis to answer the first research question, the researchers examined descriptive statistics for all items measuring public relations activities, as reported by study participants. Table 1 presents means for the level of agreement or disagreement with statements (5-point Likert scale) describing current functions and responsibilities of PR practitioners in Zimbabwe and reflecting the three types of public relations roles.

Among the most commonly performed public relations functions were publicity generation through news releases ($M = 4.33$; $SD = .893$); editing of public relations materials such as speeches and annual reports ($M = 4.29$; $SD = .859$); preparing written materials about the organization ($M = 4.30$; $SD = .925$); developing public relations strategies to support corporate strategy ($M = 4.33$; $SD = .854$); managing the implementation of public relations plans ($M = 4.33$; $SD = .943$); explaining to top management the impact of organization's behavior on society ($M = 4.23$; $SD = .880$); bringing to top management's attention any organizational behavior that erodes trust ($M = 4.22$; $SD = .940$); and expressing the company's stance on social responsibility ($M = 4.26$; $SD = .881$). The practice of media clipping ($M = 3.85$; $SD = 1.03$) and initiating dialogue with pressure groups ($M = 3.97$; $SD = .953$) were reported to be less commonly performed, yet the means still indicated considerable support for these practices by Zimbabwean PR practitioners.

4.3. Confirming Public Relations Roles in Zimbabwean Context

The first research question asked about how Zimbabwean PR practitioners define their roles and activities and what distinct roles are being enacted. The 21 survey items that represented public relations activities in organizations and designed to explore professional public relations roles were used to study public relations roles in Zimbabwe. The authors of the scale (Steyn, 1999, 2002; Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005) suggested that the scale captures three dimensions of public relations roles – technician, manager, and strategist. To explore this structure with the Zimbabwean sample, the items were subjected to principal components analysis (PCA).

Prior to analyzing the results of PCA, the suitability of the data for factor analysis was assessed. All items were deemed suitable with acceptable communality values ($>.50$). The examination of the correlation matrix revealed the presence of many coefficients of .3 and above. The Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin value was .931, exceeding the recommended value of .6 (Kaiser, 1974). Overall factorability of the data was good ($MSA = .931$ and χ^2 [df = 210] = 3255.041, $p < .000$), and univariate MSA values were also acceptable (i.e., all items are greater than .60).

The principal component analysis uncovered three components with eigenvalues exceeding 1, explaining 49.8% of the variance for the first component, 11.9% of the variance for the second component, and 6.3% of the variance for the third component. The three-component solution was further supported by Cattell's (1966)(Cattell, 1966) scree test, and 95th percentile parallel analysis (Horn, 1965; O'Connor, 2000). The final three-component solution explained a total of 67.9% of the variance. To aid in the interpretation of these three components, oblimin rotation was performed. The rotation solution revealed the presence of simple structure (Thurstone, 1947), with all three components displaying strong loadings and all variables loading substantially on only one component. There were no loadings of less than .65 on one component

(see Table 2).

The interpretation of the final three-component solution was consistent with previous research and confirmed the original conceptualization by Steyn (1999, 2002) of three different types of public relations roles operationalized in the African context. All items for components 1 (PR strategist), 2 (PR technician), and 3 (PR manager) loaded strongly. The first component consisted of 10 items (see Tables 1 and 2) and represented the role of *PR strategist* ($M = 4.12$, $n = 214$, $\alpha = .938$). The second component included six items that measured the role of *PR technician* ($M = 4.23$, $n = 222$, $\alpha = .885$). Finally, the third component was comprised of five items representing the role of PR manager ($M = 4.17$, $n = 222$, $\alpha = .909$). All three factors demonstrated scale reliability through high Cronbach's Alpha coefficients. The results of this principal component analysis supported the three-component structure and reliability of the scales measuring public relations roles, as suggested by Steyn (1999), although Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005) observed only two distinct components using mixed sample.

4.4. Understanding Public Relations and Public Relations Roles in Zimbabwean Context

To capture a baseline of how PR professionals in Zimbabwe understand and view public relations, an official definition of the concept adopted by PRSA was offered to study participants, "Public relations is a strategic communication process that builds mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and their publics" (PRSA, 2020, para. 4). The respondents were asked to indicate their agreement or disagreement with the definition. The results showed that participants, in general, supported the offered definition ($M = 4.16$; $SD = 1.23$). The overwhelming number of respondents ($n = 208$; 87.5%) indicated that they either strongly agree ($n = 121$; 50.8%) or agree ($n = 87$; 36.6%) with the PRSA's definition. The remainder of the participants ($n = 30$; 12.5%) expressed different levels of disagreement and/or indifference with the statement: 10.9% ($n = 26$) strongly disagreed, 0.8% ($n = 2$) disagreed and 0.8% ($n = 2$) neither agreed nor disagreed.

The relationship between public relations roles (technician, manager, strategist) and view of public relations (agreement with PRSA's definition) was investigated using Pearson product-moment correlation coefficient (see Table 3). The analysis showed a small correlation between the view on public relations and the technician role, $r = .157$, $n = 213$, $p < .022$. Similar results with modest effect sizes were obtained for the association between the view of public relations and manager role (r

Table 3

Pearson Product-Moment Correlations Between Public Relations Roles and Understanding of PR.

	Technician ($n = 222$)	Manager ($n = 222$)	Strategist ($n = 214$)
Public Relations as Defined by PRSA ($n = 238$)	.157*	.257**	.225**

** Correlation is significant at the $p < .01$.

* Correlation is significant at the $p < .05$.

$= .257$, $n = 212$, $p < .000$) as well as the strategist role ($r = .225$, $n = 205$, $p < .001$).

5. Discussion

This research aimed to help advance the knowledge base of public relations theory and practice with regard to Zimbabwe and offered the opportunity to widen the research coverage of the African continent. In so doing, the study explored views on public relations held by Zimbabwean professionals and the types of public relations roles typically performed. First, this research investigated whether the boundary spanning function of public relations and the associated public relations roles are performed at all three levels: 1) the strategist role at the organizational or macro level (input), 2) the manager role at the functional or meso level (throughput), and 3) the technician role at the implementational or micro level (output). Second, the study responded to the call to examine whether the structure of public relations roles differed across national and cultural borders or if they were universal. Third, the study explored the relationship between public relations roles enacted by Zimbabwean professionals and their understanding of the field. In addition, this paper provided a description of public relations education and background on the public relations industry and its professionals in Zimbabwe. The discussion of findings and contributions to the literature are presented below.

5.1. Boundary Spanning and Public Relations Functions in Zimbabwean Organizations

Grunig and Hunt (1984) argued that public relations' boundary spanning function plays a pivotal role in organizations, allowing them to remain open, responsive, and competitive. This research demonstrated

Table 2

Pattern and Structure Matrix for PCA with Oblimin Rotation of Three-Factor Solution for PR Roles.

Item	Pattern Coefficients			Structure coefficients			Communalities
	Strategist Comp. 1	Technician Comp. 2	Manager Comp. 3	Strategist Comp. 1	Technician Comp. 2	Manager Comp. 3	
V4.7	.853			.861		-.439	.745
V4.6	.831			.838		-.485	.719
V4.8	.813			.868	.446	-.505	.762
V4.5	.811			.827		-.491	.701
V4.3	.799			.803	.334	-.424	.643
V4.10	.785			.791	.467	-.352	.664
V4.2	.784			.794	.422	-.385	.644
V4.4	.759			.721		-.347	.527
V4.1	.701			.761	.312	-.506	.602
V4.9	.673			.775	.528	-.471	.647
V2.1		.808			.757	-.346	.580
V2.2		.747		.302	.755	-.419	.573
V2.3		.714		.521	.817	-.511	.704
V2.5		.694		.439	.811	-.573	.690
V2.4		.670		.447	.795	-.571	.669
V2.6		.652		.520	.801	-.578	.695
V3.4			-.925	.427	.423	-.884	.785
V3.3			-.841	.468	.539	-.889	.799
V3.2			-.760	.489	.578	-.861	.764
V3.1			-.743	.473	.475	-.830	.657
V3.5			-.720	.536	.516	-.830	.710

that the practiced public relations roles in Zimbabwe indeed enable practitioners to perform all three boundary spanning functions within organizations. In other words, organizations in Zimbabwe engage in public relations practices and activities that encourage information exchange via input, throughput, and output processes.

Participants' responses illustrated that Zimbabwean PR practitioners' daily activities are comprised of a variety of tasks dealing with all three boundary spanning functions. For example, practitioners reported regularly working on output tasks, such as traditional public relations functions such as generating publicity via news releases, preparing and editing documents, and online content. The throughput tasks included developing strategies, managing campaign implementation, measuring, and evaluating program outcomes. The input function was performed by doing research and advocating for the needs of key internal and external publics, articulating the organization's stance on CSR, among other duties. As argued by Cutlip et al. (2006), these three boundary spanning functions support information exchange in organizations, encouraging two-way communication and relationship building via strategies afforded by public relations. Findings from this study indicate that the Zimbabwean public relations profession has embraced the value of boundary spanning, and Zimbabwean PR practitioners seem to be serving as boundary spanners with one foot in the organization and one foot outside. Future research needs to investigate this assertion further.

5.2. Public Relations Roles in Zimbabwe

The analysis focused on three roles: Dozier's (1983) technician and manager roles, as well as Steyn's (1999) strategist role. Consistent with previous research, Zimbabwean PR practitioners perform day-to-day activities associated with Dozier's manager and technician roles found in most contexts. In addition, Steyn's strategist role emerged as one of the main roles with which Zimbabwean professionals identify. This indicates that the public relations function in Zimbabwean organizations is being performed at the micro, meso and macro levels as all three roles were present, allowing the organizations to perform all three boundary spanning functions (input, output, throughput) necessary for open systems and essential for the organization's survival in the competitive global environment.

Importantly, factor analysis confirmed the existence of three distinct components as three distinct public relations roles. This finding is similar to Steyn (1999) but different from Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005). Although Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005) recognized the existence of three public relations roles among practitioners in Southern and Eastern African countries, their findings revealed a combined technician and manager role as responsibilities between these two functions overlapped.

As an important contribution to the literature on global public relations, this study further confirms and solidifies the role of the PR practitioner as a strategist, complementing the works by Steyn (1999, 2009), Tindall and Holtzhausen (2011), and Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005). The statistical analysis demonstrated that the strategist role was widely accepted by Zimbabwean PR practitioners, indicating the growing importance of the input function in Zimbabwe's public relations practice. As Steyn (2009) contended, in addition to having PR practitioners enacting the traditional technician - manager roles, to be excellent, organizations should have practitioners perform the PR strategist role as well.

The distinct role of the strategist observed among the Zimbabwean practitioners may be explained by the growth of social media globally. The strategist role associated with the input function becomes more and more critical due to the rise of social media. The increasing role of social media in public relations practice certainly offers more opportunities for "input" information flow (it's easier to get data, social listening, etc.) and creates more volatile organizational environments that require more research and constant environmental scanning. These activities are

associated with the strategist role because practitioners in this role are responsible for performing the input boundary spanning function within an organization (Steyn, 1999).

However, as Tindall and Holtzhausen (2011) suggested, public relations roles are not mutually exclusive and, in fact, can be performed cross-functionally. Specifically, because social media represents a volatile media environment that requires more research and constant social listening, it is also associated with an output function and the technician role as the needs to drive engagement demand more content output. As underscored by the Ngondo (2019) study, while Zimbabwean PR practitioners are dedicating a sizable portion of their daily public relations duties to digital and social media, performed mostly at the micro/-implementational level (output), the practitioners also believe that the public relations department should be responsible for monitoring and managing social and digital media as well, implying the input and throughput boundary spanning functions. Future research should investigate further the connection between the growing importance of social media in public relations and differentiated or integrated public relations roles.

In general, studies of the public relations roles on the African continent provided mixed results with roles blurred and merged (Steyn, 2009; Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011; Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005). In this context, Zimbabwe's public relations practice differs from the practice in its neighboring nations, such as South Africa, as practitioners appear to perform the roles of technician, manager, and strategist quite distinctly. This finding answers the question that the structure and performance of public relations roles indeed differ across cultural and national borders.

5.3. Understandings of Public Relations in Zimbabwe

In Zimbabwe, public relations is understood very similarly to the Western/American view, as the majority of respondents expressed agreement with PRSA's definition. This is somewhat consistent with Muchena's (2017) findings, who argued that Zimbabwean practitioners perceive public relations as a strategic management function. This is key as the field had faced challenges in clearly defining itself. This finding provides insight into how the field is defined around the globe.

The views on public relations held by practitioners may impact how public relations is practiced and, therefore, constrain professional roles. The small correlation between the public relations definition and public relations roles did not provide enough insight into whether views and perspectives on public relations affect the types of roles practiced by Zimbabwean practitioners. All practiced public relations roles were associated with the PRSA's definition. Still, the roles of the manager (throughput function) and the strategist (input function) demonstrated the strongest relationship, indicating Zimbabwean practitioner's commitment to practice public relations as a strategic management function. This finding in itself may suggest future avenues for exploration of the topic. If interpreted cautiously, the higher correlation between manager and strategist roles and PRSA's definition may demonstrate that commitment to professionalization is associated with higher-level public relations roles.

5.4. Public Relations Professionals in Zimbabwe

As another unique contribution to the literature, the study provided background on Zimbabwean PR professionals and public relations education. Two main takeaways offered: Zimbabwe is yet to develop formal public relations education programs, and the public relations labor force consists of professionals coming from different fields and with various professional and educational backgrounds.

Overall, based on the studied sample, the study confirms the sparsely available depictions of the public relations labor force in Zimbabwe, showing that marketing education dominates among PR practitioners. Notably, the intertwining of marketing and public relations continues to

be problematic as more practitioners had marketing degrees compared to public relations. As such, this finding confirms Oksiutycz and Nhedzi's (2018) assertion and Muchena's (2017) findings of Zimbabwean PR practitioners being transplants from other disciplines. The respondents had degrees from various backgrounds, namely marketing, mass communication, business administration, and journalism. Practitioners with public relations degrees were a mere 14% of the sample.

Despite the challenges of formal training outlined by Muchena (2017, 2018), the majority of Zimbabwean PR practitioners seem to understand what public relations is. As indicated by the overwhelming support for the PRSA's definition, practitioners treat and understand public relations as strategic management of communication that builds mutually beneficial relationships.

As the literature outlined, understanding how marketing, journalism, and related fields complement public relations is important, especially for integrated marketing communications and strategic communication. Akin to Azionya et al. (2019) who developed and emphasized a Value Based Education approach to public relations education in South Africa, Zimbabwean practitioners and academics should continue to develop the public relations curriculum until it is offered as its own degree at universities across the country. Moreover, practitioners should be encouraged to be members of public relations professional organizations as this not only keeps them connected to the field; it also provides opportunities for training through certifications.

5.5. Limitations and Future Research

Despite several limitations of this research, the study provides a series of valuable insights into how public relations is understood and practiced in Zimbabwe. However, it is important to stress that the researchers relied on snowball sampling to recruit participants; therefore, these results cannot be generalized to all PR professionals in Zimbabwe. In addition, the data is based on respondents' self-reporting, with some possibly misrepresenting their job functions.

Now that Zimbabwean practitioners' public relations roles have been defined, future research should explore which public relations models are practiced in Zimbabwe and how they compare across the globe via a cross-cultural comparison. Likewise, investigating the impact culture has on how public relations is practiced may provide a further understanding of the differences and similarities observed in public relations roles (van Heerden & Rensberg, 2005), in Zimbabwe and across the globe. For example, Tindall and Holtzhausen's study (2011) found that political and cultural environments shape the context and content of public relations roles in South Africa.

Future research should also investigate Zimbabwe's public relations from the Global Capability Framework (Gregory & Fawkes, 2019), which captures professional public relations competencies. Understanding commonly shared public relations roles and duties will help develop professional public relations education in Zimbabwe by incorporating the needed skills and expertise into the curriculum.

It is also essential to better understand the three factors that may influence public relations roles: professionalization (moving from one-way to two-way), the public relations curriculum, and organizational settings and environment. As van Heerden and Rensberg (2005) explained, determining what is being taught in African institutions and organizations will impact the roles and perceptions of African PR practitioners.

6. Conclusion

The recognition of cultural diversity in the practice and theory of public relations propels the development of the discipline, opening doors to new ideas, and shaping new approaches. This study responds to the call for more diversified research from Africa and contributes to the promotion of cultural inclusivity in public relations scholarship (Creedon & Al-Khaja, 2019). Public relations roles are one of the

well-researched areas of public relations, yet most research is conducted within the U.S. In Africa, Zimbabwe is now among the few countries where public relations roles are examined. While examining public relations roles generally emphasizes skills and effective communication, studying the diverse practices opens up spaces for acknowledging cultural differences (Dutta & Elers, 2020). Azionya et al. (2019) reiterated that scholarship from emerging markets provides "perspectives that inform the cultural scope of communication research and practice, and issues that are not apparent to scholars working in different societies"(p.2).

The results of this study allow scholars and practitioners to extend and clarify previous work on public relations roles in Africa, confirm the existence of technician, manager, and strategist roles, as well as offer unique insights into the public relations activities and the composition of the labor force in Zimbabwe.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors report no declarations of interest.

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